TALK ONE

1 Only Begotten in the Flesh

"And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."

JOHN 1:14 · ABOUT 7 MINUTES

A biography usually begins with a person's parents. Matthew begins the life of Jesus that way, with a genealogy, and Luke tells us about the angel who visited Mary. John begins before Jesus was born, with the Son beside His Father. "The Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us," John writes, "and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father."

All of us are children of God, so the title has to mean something more than that. The Greek word John uses is monogenes, and many newer Bibles translate it "one and only." John uses the word four times in his gospel, always about Jesus, including the familiar verse: "For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son." What makes Jesus the Only Begotten? The words "in the flesh," which we find in Restoration scripture, help answer that question.

Michael, God the Father, came to this earth and became Adam. Adam had children while he was mortal. Cain and Abel were born during that part of their father's life. Later, after he had accomplished his work, Adam was changed into a glorified condition. It was in this condition that God fathered Jesus Christ with Mary. Sarah M. Kimball, a leader of the Relief Society, said that the Prophet Joseph Smith once told her brother and Bishop George Miller that when Mary "was on her way to the hill country she was met by the Father and the Angel Gabriel and the latter performed the marriage between the Father and Mary." The distinction depends on the Father's condition when Christ was begotten. Adam's children were born to a mortal father. Jesus was born to that same Father after the Father had returned to

glory. Mary was mortal, so Jesus had a mortal mother and a glorified Father. This is why we call Christ the Only Begotten of the Father in the flesh.

Nephi calls Christ "the Only Begotten of the Father, yea, even the Father of heaven and of earth," and says Christ would "manifest himself unto them in the flesh." By "the Father of heaven and of earth," Nephi is explaining who Christ's Father is. Michael is the Father of heaven, and Adam is that same Father on earth.

But having a glorified Father did not mean Jesus had already received the Father's fullness. In section 93, John the Baptist records that Jesus "received not of the fulness at first, but continued from grace to grace." Before coming to earth, Christ had been with the Father. Christ had intelligence and glory and understood the plan, but had not yet lived in a mortal body or been resurrected. The Son still needed to receive a body, bring it under the rule of His spirit, and remain faithful throughout His life. His own salvation depended on completing the work He had agreed to do.

So the Son of a glorified Father lived a mortal life as we do. He got tired and hungry. John records that Jesus sat down at a well in Samaria because He was "wearied with his journey." John tells us that Jesus wept at the tomb of His friend Lazarus and that, on the cross, Jesus said, "I thirst." John had walked with Jesus, listened to His teaching, and watched how He treated people. When John wrote, "We beheld his glory," he was remembering someone he had known. Glory in scripture can describe God's greatness becoming visible to people, and John saw that greatness in a mortal man.

The night before his death, Jesus prayed to the Father for His disciples. "I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me," He said. "The glory which thou gavest me I have given them." Jesus wanted His disciples to receive the words and glory the Father had given Him. In that same prayer, Jesus asked "that they all may be one; as thou, Father, art in me, and I in thee, that they also may be one in us."

We may talk to our fathers every day and still want very different things. Jesus and the Father are never apart in purpose. Jesus wants what the Father wants and has given His life to doing the Father's will. Becoming one with them means learning to share that purpose and live by it. Jesus also says this

prayer is for everyone who will believe through the disciples' words. We are reading those words now. The people Jesus prayed for include us. Later in the prayer, Jesus tells the Father, "Thou lovedst me before the foundation of the world." Jesus knew the Father's love long before Bethlehem. Now the Son asks that we may be with Him and share in that love.

Section 84 describes our relationship with the Father and the Son through the priesthood covenant. Whoever receives the Lord's servants receives the Lord, and whoever receives the Lord receives the Father. Then comes the promise: "And all that my Father hath shall be given unto him." That promise helps us understand what it means to call Jesus an older brother. We use family words so often that we can forget we are still learning what they mean. Jesus is an older brother who has received everything His Father has and wants the rest of the family to receive it too. Through the Atonement, Christ makes it possible for us to return, grow, and receive what the Father offers.

This year our school will spend a week at a time on a name of Christ. We begin with the Only Begotten of the Father in the flesh because it brings us to the beginning of His mortal life: who His Father is and what the Son came here to do. The rest of this week, and the rest of the year, we will follow Jesus through that work.

John wrote his gospel many years after walking beside Jesus. When John told the story, he began with the Son who had been with the Father and had come to live among us. "We beheld his glory."

I have not seen what John saw.

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The script ends here. The speaker's own testimony follows.